

The Integration of Polyvagal-Based Interventions and Education into the Counseling Practice

Dr. Lynn Bohecker

Cynthia Trower

Breanna McNeal, Tracy Meyer, Raymond Wagoner

Abstract

[see PRISMA guidelines and specific journal guidelines]

(Write this last)

The Integration of Polyvagal-Based Interventions and Education into the Counseling Practice

Introduction

[Rationale: Describe the rationale for the review in the context of what is already known]

[Objectives: Provide an explicit statement of the question(s) the review will address]

[Rationale: The rationale for this manuscript is the gap in the literature related to the research question]

Methods

To answer the research question “How can Polyvagal Theory be integrated into the counseling profession?” a combination of Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses (PRISMA), systematic review methods (including Population, Intervention, Comparison, Outcomes, and Study (PICOS)), and content analysis was utilized. This method was chosen as a rigorous, proven design for gathering and abductively inferring contextual phenomena, which can then be reduced into manageable data suitable for application to a specific research question.

PRISMA

The faculty instructors for the course this project was designed for performed an initial search of two counseling journal databases. Using Academic Search Ultimate and Sociology Ultimate databases American Counseling Association, and other counseling journals were searched. This initial query in these two databases searched for the words polyvagal, counseling, or therapy. With this initial search utilizing only the counseling journals, there were no results containing the word polyvagal. Broadening the search for articles that include the term polyvagal

required the inclusion of various databases. This secondary search utilized Academic Search Ultimate, APA PsycInfo, CINAHL Ultimate, Education Research Complete, Education Source, Educational Administration Abstracts, ERIC, Psychology and Behavioral Sciences Collection, Social Work Abstracts, SocINDEX with Full Text, Sociology Source Ultimate, MEDLINE Ultimate, and MEDLINE with Full Text. Using the Boolean search operators “AND” and “OR” the keywords polyvagal and counseling, therapy, or psychology were combined to find articles related to the research question of “how can Polyvagal Theory be integrated into the counseling profession?” After the results were returned, the term trauma was added to the search to reduce the total number of results. The final query used the Boolean search string (polyvagal theory AND (counsel* OR therap* OR psych*)) AND trauma. Narrowing the search further by articles published between 2019 and 2023 yielded 103 articles. Excluding the duplicate articles from this list yielded a total of 41 articles. One of the articles, Hanazawa 2022, was previewed in the Japanese language. A request was made through an interlibrary loan for this article in English. However, this request was denied because the article is not available in English. Since none of the authors speak Japanese, this article was excluded from the selection process, leaving 40 articles to review. Throughout the review, an Excel table was utilized to manage, categorize, create inclusion/exclusion criteria, code the remaining articles, and manage the content analysis.

Selection Process

The team employed the PICOS strategy as the method of selecting articles returned from the final search. The selection was begun by dividing the 40 remaining articles into four sections. The four sections were created by using the Excel worksheet and selecting the first ten articles listed for the first group, the second ten articles for the second group, the third ten articles for the third group, and the fourth ten articles for the fourth group. Each team member then took a group

of articles to begin selection for inclusion or exclusion. Once each member had identified perspective criteria and candidates for inclusion or exclusion, the team conferred on each item. Once consensus had been made on each item to include or exclude the following criteria were identified. The inclusion criteria included articles of rigorous study relating to the research question. Criteria included identifiable interventions with clients based on the Polyvagal Theory, studies relating insights valuable for nuanced aspects of the counseling profession, treatment protocol identified by the study, the study offered measures with suggestions for clinical practice, or the study provided information on how interventions based on the Polyvagal Theory create change. The exclusion criteria were opinion articles, articles not based on scientific research, articles describing presentations rather than a study or a research design, articles in languages other than English, and articles with a population of individuals under the age of 18. Withdrawing articles that fell within the exclusion criteria generated a remainder of 20 articles. See the PRISMA diagram below for an illustration of the process (Table 1).

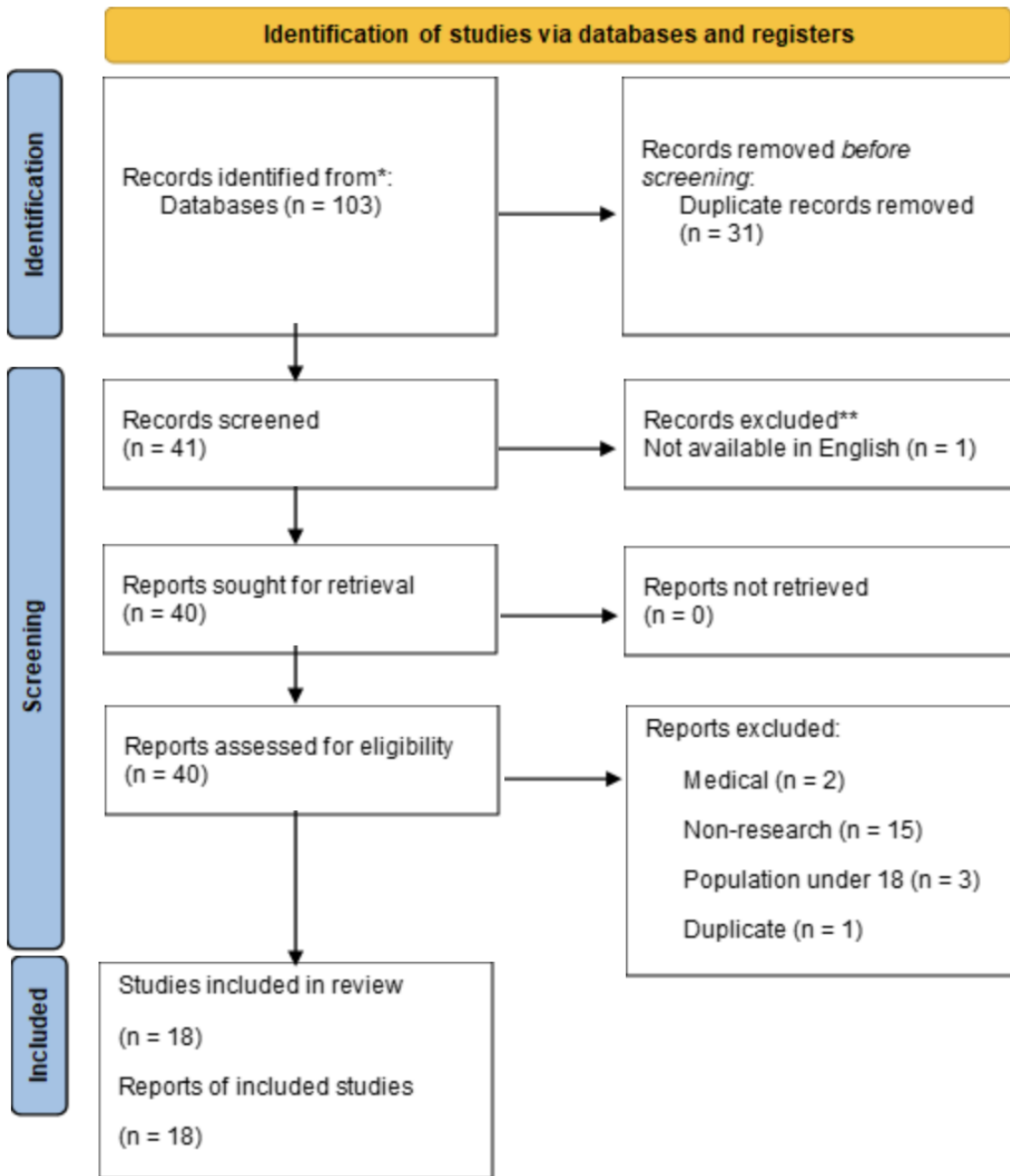


Table 1 PRISMA results

Content Analysis

Content analysis was begun by dividing the 20 remaining articles into four sections. The four sections were created by virtue of the selection process. Each team member took the group of included articles from his or her selection process to begin content analysis. Each team member combed his or her articles for content related to the research question. Once each team

member distilled the content, they paraphrased the pertinent data in sentences and paragraphs ready for inclusion in the results and discussion sections. A Word document was used in this process to track notes, discussions, and paraphrased material to include.

Data Coding Procedure

Similarly to content analysis, coding was done in an independent yet cohesive style. Trower, Meyer, McNeal, and Wagoner independently identified code words from the articles in their selection groups by underlining, circling, noticing, and noting repeated, critical, thematic, and article-centric words on printed articles. Once each author identified these words independently, Meyer took the words from each and all included articles and placed them in an Excel worksheet. Using the tools in the Excel program, Meyer then created columns for the list of words from each article. Following this, Meyer sorted the words and eliminated repeated words. Once this process was completed, the four authors met again and created categories for the terms in an effort to simplify the list.

Results

[Present the synthesized themes to answer or respond to the research question]

Four reviewers analyzed the articles for inclusion or exclusion into the study. The abstracts were reviewed as the exclusion and inclusion criteria was being built, and the full articles were then reviewed. Authors discussed any uncertainty about whether to include or exclude an article. 20 studies were ultimately included in the study. (describe briefly each study)

-See excel of codewords

-Include findings from the individual articles and what the results show overall (categorize them)

Limitations

[Present limitations of this review]

Does not include children

Small sample sizes

Discussion and Implications

[Present a narrative of what the results mean. How does this inform counseling or counselor education? What recommendations are you making? What further research is lacking or needed?]

References